

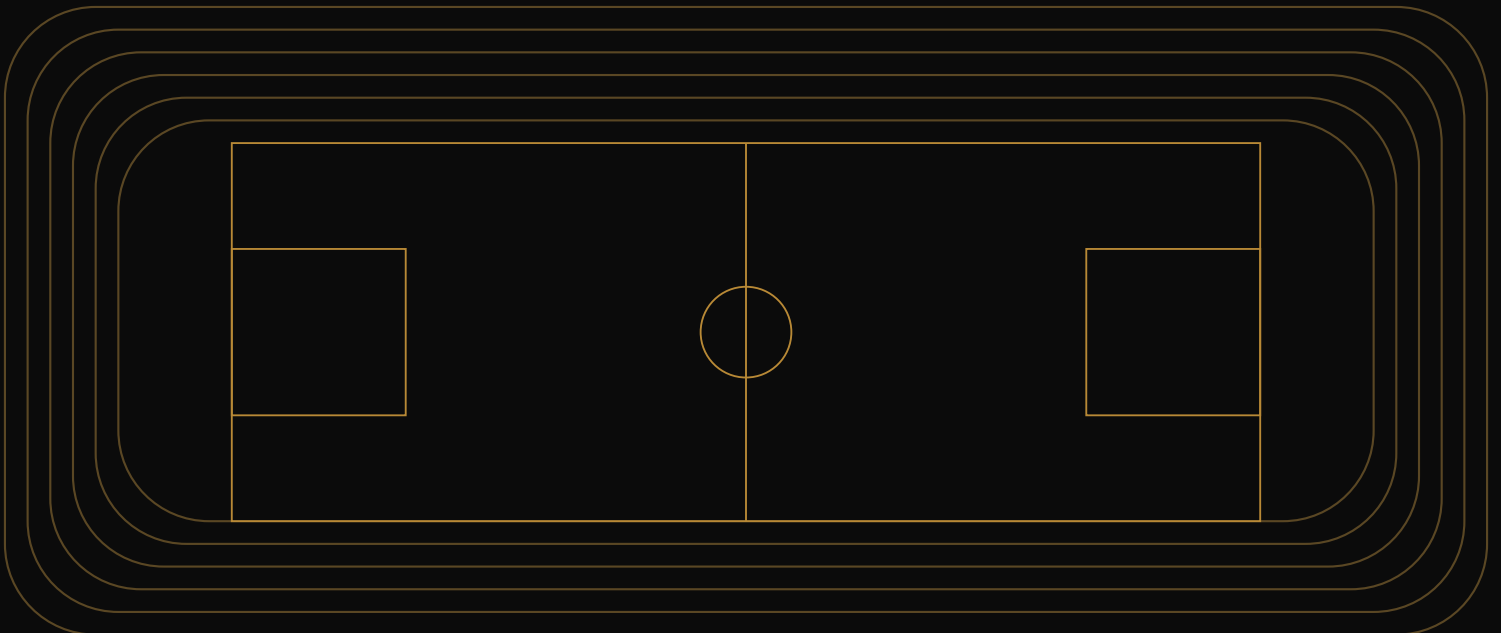
OWNER-RUN SERVICE BUSINESS | PUBLIC VERSION

THE MIND THAT BUILT THE BUSINESS KEEPS BUILDING THE NEXT STADIUM

“The business keeps building the full stadium before checking whether anyone is coming to the match.”

A blunt commercial review of the projects, platforms and “big answers” that have absorbed time, money and attention before the basics were proven.

Names, organisations, locations, dates, figures and other identifying details have been redacted or generalised. The commercial findings and recommendations are unchanged.



Prepared by Tom Arrington

Managing Director | Arrington Consultancy | Public case study

Ideas are not in short supply. Finished work is.

The owner has built something substantial. He sees opportunity quickly and his mind does not switch off. That same trait is now producing nine starts for every finish, and AI has made the gap between a rough thought and a finished-looking programme almost disappear. The owner needs to apply the project rules and the eight questions to himself before an idea leaves his head.

A business decision has an owner, a cost, a deadline and a way of knowing whether it worked. Too many projects in the business have had a name, a grand promise and a large document, but no proper finish line.

1

A real problem appears

2

A new magic bullet is found

3

The idea becomes a huge plan

4

Time and money go in

5

The result is not measured

6

Attention moves to the next idea

THE TEST BEFORE ANY MORE MONEY IS SPENT

How does this win, support or retain more customers through the business?

If the business cannot answer that clearly, agree the owner and show the evidence, the project does not start.

Nine ideas. The basics come first.

IDEA	REALITY	DECISION
CRM merry-go-round	Paid, changed and still not reliably usable	STOP
Website rebuild	Multiple builds and changes. No proven lead engine	STOP
Large AI platform	A full platform designed before a single pilot	PAUSE
High-profile referral programme	A confirmed relationship. Repeat demand not proven	CONTROLLED TEST
Tiered paid service offer	Designed offer. No clear evidence of launch	PARK
Referral consortium	Referral value may exist. Formal model is unproven	MEASURE
Third-party platform proposal	Ambitious idea, not a current business priority	ARCHIVE
Digital Workspace Programme	Finish the basics before building the umbrella	STRIP BACK
Staff development plan	A genuine need. Test the small version first	30-DAY PILOT

RECOMMENDATION

Nothing on this page is banned forever. But none of it gets to jump ahead of working lead control, one finished website, clear numbers and cash collection.



Four directions in five months. Still no settled working system.

STOP

Over several months, the business moved from its old bespoke CRM to one proposed replacement, bought an annual licence for another, considered further platforms and then made the current CRM the answer. A full build was proposed, substantial management time was allocated and the team later recorded nine material failures.

TEAM-RECORDED FAILURE

Staff cannot reliably see, create, report on, notify or move leads. Duplicate data can overwrite an existing contact. |

THE PROMISE

One agreed process from first enquiry to confirmed work and commission.

THE REALITY

The product changed faster than the business process. Staff were left with a system that blocked basic work.

THE COMMERCIAL RISK

More missed follow-up, unreliable data, another sunk cost and another round of retraining.

RECOMMENDATION

Do not buy another CRM. Fix the current CRM, formally accept it, or recover the cost. A new CRM will not fix a process nobody has agreed.

Evidence: supplier correspondence, CRM invoices, implementation plans, the current CRM proposal and the team's recorded defect review.



A lead engine that has spent more time being rebuilt than being tested.

STOP

draft-site / Squarespace / Manus / Squarespace again

UNDER CONSTRUCTION

The original supplier spent roughly a year developing a Squarespace site while waiting for content, decisions and feedback. A separate Manus site was then developed as part of the review.

1

FIRST

The supplier's Squarespace build already existed but had not reached a final commercial decision.

2

NEXT

A separate Manus build was developed with CRM integration and broader capability.

3

THEN

Manus was ruled out as the public-site platform and the site was rebuilt in Squarespace.

4

AFTER THAT

Before the Squarespace rebuild had been allowed to settle, attention moved towards a new AI project and a possible funding opportunity.

SEVERAL THOUSAND POUNDS

Website spend reported during the review. The full invoice trail still needs verifying.

NO PROVEN ENGINE

The site has not been left alone long enough to prove qualified enquiries or confirmed customers.

RECOMMENDATION

Pick one route. Finish it. Measure it. No further strategic rewrite until the chosen version has had a fair test in the market.

Evidence: supplier website correspondence and Squarespace work; the Manus build and comparison workbook; the AI platform recommendation; later AI funding discussions; website cost reported during the review and marked for verification.



A full platform designed in under an hour.

PAUSE

In under an hour, four staged documents turned an idea into a website, CRM, messaging system, customer portal, customer support centre, AI presenter, assessment scoring and simulated sessions, dashboards, funding proposition and international growth model.

UNDER
AN HOUR

WEBSITE

CRM

MESSAGING

CUSTOMER PORTAL

CUSTOMER SUPPORT

AI PRESENTER

ASSESSMENT SCORE

SIMULATED SESSIONS

DASHBOARDS

FUNDING

GLOBAL SCALE

WHAT IS NOT THERE YET

- × Approved business case
- × Confirmed development budget
- × Named delivery owner
- × Working customer portal
- × Live AI coach
- × Measured pilot
- × Business data proving return
- × Staff operating agreement

RECOMMENDATION

Interesting idea. Not a programme.

Pilot one useful component with a small group of customers. No portal, no investor document and no platform spend until the pilot proves something.

Evidence: four staged AI-platform documents created in a single working session.



One confirmed customer became a flagship programme within days.

CONTROLLED TEST

WHAT IS CONFIRMED

The first customer relationship is confirmed. The records contain the proposal, acceptance, payment and service documentation.

WHAT IS NOT PROVEN

There is no evidence yet of a repeatable referral pipeline: no confirmed referral mechanism, additional qualified enquiries, further customers, commission income or operating commitment from the referring organisation.

1

FIRST

A referral pathway is designed with reference codes, a landing page, an application fee and fee reductions.

2

NEXT

The idea expands into multiple pathways, events, visits, placements, community activity and possible adoption by other influential organisations.

3

THEN

A substantial legacy proposal is prepared and sent.

THE SIX-MONTH TEST

One named referring contact

A limited number of referral codes

Target for qualified enquiries

Target for confirmed customers

A fixed review date

No events or bespoke technology before referrals

RECOMMENDATION

One customer is not evidence of demand. Call it a programme once the referrals repeat.

Evidence: referral-pathway proposals, the legacy programme document and the first customer's proposal, acceptance, payment and service records.



Designed. Named. Expanded. Not yet made to pay.

TIERED PAID SERVICE OFFER

The idea: Charge customers different fees for enhanced support. The evidence: A detailed offer and website table existed, but I found no clear launch approval, payment trail, assigned customers, delivery procedure or sales result. Decision: Park it. Do not revive it until the business knows whether charging supports or damages trust, and what the promised service actually costs to deliver.

PARK

THE REFERRAL CONSORTIUM

The idea: Several agencies combine agreements, share commission and use a shared tracking tool. The evidence: The proposal exists and the business has established referral relationships. What is not proven is that the formal consortium launched as described or that its shared tool was built. Decision: Measure the relationships that already work. Do not build consortium software until referral volume earns it.

MEASURE

THIRD-PARTY PLATFORM PROPOSAL

The idea: A national, government-funded AI platform with very large user and revenue targets. The evidence: This is third-party material, not clearly a business-owned project. I found no business pilot, funding, users, revenue or defined delivery role. Decision: Archive as third-party material unless someone can state the business's role, commitment and next commercial step.

ARCHIVE



One needs cutting back. One needs proving small.

DIGITAL WORKSPACE PROGRAMME

STRIP BACK

The programme joins the website, document system, CRM, messaging, permissions, a staff portal, learning hub, knowledge base and future automation.

The problem: This can make unfinished basics look like a transformation programme. The CRM was still broken, the website was unsettled and the commercial reporting was fragmented.

Recommendation: Strip it to three outcomes only:

- 1. The current CRM works.**
- 2. One website is finished.**
- 3. Staff know where the right documents live.**

STAFF DEVELOPMENT PLAN

30-DAY PILOT

This starts with a genuine need: develop one team member's knowledge and confidence. The concern is not the aim. It is how quickly the answer grew into multiple guides, partner profiles, weekly presentations, advanced topics and contributions to the wider AI-platform idea.

Recommendation: Run the 30-day version:

- one service guide
- one priority partner profile
- one presentation
- agreed time allowance
- review with the team member, manager and operational lead

Expand only if the pilot works.

RECOMMENDATION

A large plan can feel like progress. It is only progress when somebody uses it, it improves the work and the result can be seen.

Evidence: the digital workspace programme and the staff development plan.



The invoices are not the whole cost. Staff time and delayed campaigns cost more than the software did.

SEVERAL THOUSAND POUNDS

Verified annual licence for the previous CRM.

VERIFIED SUPPORT COST

IT support, equipment setup and integration work. Not all of it is CRM cost.

FURTHER SPEND PROPOSED

First-year options for the current CRM. Actual payment still needs confirming.

SEVERAL THOUSAND POUNDS WEBSITE

Reported during the review. The full invoice trail has not yet been matched and should be verified.

THE HIDDEN BILL

The hidden cost also includes leads that were not visible, management time lost to configuration, staff meetings spent discussing the same fault and useful work pushed aside by another rebuild.

Before any more money is committed, the business needs one reconciled schedule showing software, suppliers, website work, CRM work, refunds available, subscriptions still running and the staff time being consumed.

Evidence: previous CRM invoice, supplier support receipt, current CRM investment proposal and website cost reported during the review and marked for verification.



Protect the customers, the leads and the cash already within reach.

1

MAKE THE CURRENT CRM PASS AN ACCEPTANCE TEST

Resolve the nine defects. Prove that staff can see, create, move, notify, report and close leads. No replacement CRM.

2

FINISH ONE WEBSITE

Choose one route, put it live, track qualified enquiries and confirmed customers. Stop competing builds.

3

FOLLOW CONFIRMED WORK THROUGH TO CASH

For every confirmed customer: commission expected, purchase order, invoice, cash received, referral payment and net amount retained.

4

WORK THE TOP 20 PARTNERS

Current terms, last qualified enquiry, last confirmed customer, last payment, next opportunity and net contribution.

5

RECOVER OR CANCEL OVERLAPPING COSTS

Confirm the previous CRM, the current CRM, website and supplier spend. Seek correction, credit or refund where work was not delivered.

NO MATERIAL SPEND YET ON

Another CRM | Full AI platform | AI talking head | Customer portal | Consortium software | Another website route | High-profile events or bespoke technology | Investor-grade platform brochure



No more projects that arrive with a name but no finish line.

1

WHAT PROBLEM ARE WE ACTUALLY SOLVING?

2

WHAT COMMERCIAL RESULT SHOULD CHANGE?

3

WHO OWNS IT?

4

WHAT WILL IT COST IN MONEY AND STAFF TIME?

5

WHAT EXISTING WORK STOPS OR MOVES?

6

WHAT EVIDENCE WILL PROVE IT WORKED?

7

WHEN IS THE REVIEW DATE?

8

AT WHAT POINT DO WE STOP THIS?

RULES BEFORE A PROJECT STARTS

- No project begins on the day it is presented.
- No project is complete because somebody says it is. The evidence must exist.
- No project gets more than one extension without a full review.
- If staff recommend stopping and the owner continues, both positions and the reason are recorded.
- Starting is easy. Finishing takes the time and the money.

Every current idea gets a decision, a deadline and proof.

PROJECT	DECISION NOW	DEADLINE	PROOF
Current CRM	Fix and formally accept. No replacement.	30 days	Nine issues closed. Five live cases completed end to end.
Website	Choose one route and stop the others.	14 days	Live, tracked and no competing build.
High-profile referral programme	Run a six-month controlled test.	Set now	Named contact, referral target, confirmed-customer target, review date.
AI platform	Park the platform. Define one pilot only.	90 days	A small pilot with real customers and measured use.
Tiered paid service offer	Formally park or close.	14 days	Written decision and no hidden delivery commitment.
Consortium	Measure existing relationships.	60 days	Customers, confirmed work, commission, payout and net result by partner.
Digital Workspace	Cut back to three basic outcomes.	30 days	CRM works, one website finished, correct document homes agreed.
Staff development	Run the small pilot.	30 days	One guide, one profile, one presentation and team review.

RECOMMENDATION

The test is whether the business can answer: what are we doing, who owns it, what happens next and did it make money or improve the customer experience?

THE AMBITION IS FINE. STARTING THE NEXT THING BEFORE THE LAST ONE WORKS IS NOT.

The business has established relationships, capable people and customers to serve.

The problem is treating every new idea as the answer before the last answer has been made to work.

BUILD THE CROWD FIRST. Then build the next stand.

Tom Arrington

Managing Director, Arrington Consultancy

tom@arringtonconsultancy.com | 01752 477026 | www.arringtonconsultancy.com



What this judgement is built on, and what still needs checking.

E1

Supplier correspondence Website deadline, campaigns held back and a proposed CRM move.

E2

Previous CRM invoice Annual licence and verified cost.

E3

CRM implementation plan Concerns and warning against repeating the same process problem in another system.

E4

Current CRM proposal Scope and proposed first-year investment.

E9

High-profile referral proposals Pathway, flagship programme and legacy expansion.

E10

First customer records Proposal, acceptance, payment and service evidence.

E11

Tiered paid service design Proposed customer-paid service levels.

E12

Referral consortium proposal Multi-agency model and proposed shared tool.

E5

Management correspondence Substantial time allocated to the CRM while design and import questions remained open.

E6

CRM meeting report Nine material staff and system issues.

E7

Website positioning paper Core website positioning reopened.

E8

AI-platform documents Platform scope, delivery claims and presentation ambition.

E13

Third-party platform draft National platform proposal and ambitious revenue model.

E14

Digital workspace programme Integrated transformation scope.

E15

Staff development programme Proposed development scope.

E16

Supplier receipt Covering support, equipment setup and integration work.

DO NOT OVERSTATE THESE POINTS

- The website cost was reported during the review and still needs matching to invoices and bank payments.
- The current CRM proposal shows options, not confirmed payment.
- The high-profile referral programme is new and may have informal enquiries not visible in the searched files.
- I have not proven that no customer ever bought a paid service tier, or that the consortium produced no customer.
- The national platform proposal appears third-party. Do not describe it as the owner's failed project without further evidence.